

Retiring the BELL CURVE

Built for predictability, the bell curve struggles in today's workplaces. Organisations are now being challenged to redesign performance evaluation systems to reflect how employees generate value

BY MAMTA SHARMA



ARCHANA DIDN'T QUESTION

performance management until it questioned her.

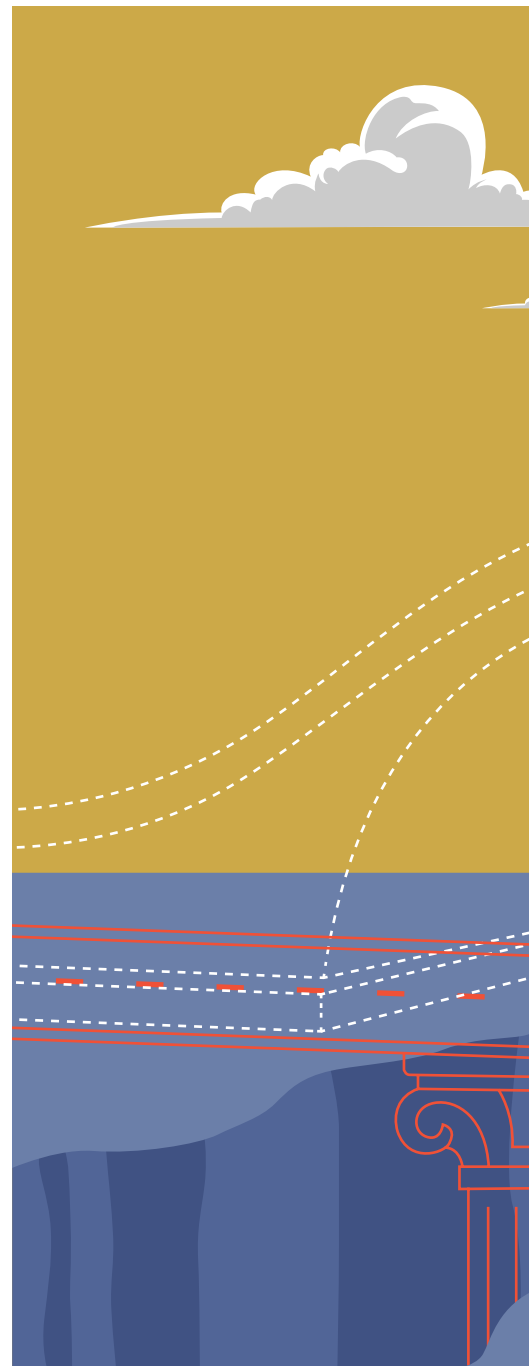
After a year of stretching across multiple projects, adapting to shifting client demands, and being told consistently that she was doing well, the appraisal outcome felt jarring. "In fast-paced teams like ours, most people are genuinely strong performers," says Archana (name changed), an IT professional at a services and consulting company in

Bengaluru. "Yet, during appraisal cycles, managers are still forced to fit employees into predefined bell curves, even when the ground reality doesn't support it."

What unsettled her most was the disconnect between everyday feedback and final outcomes.

Employees are encouraged throughout the year, told they are stepping up, only to land in an 'average' bucket during calibration. "Even if unintentional," she says, "that gap slowly erodes trust in the process."

Archana's experience is increasingly familiar across corporate India, and it helps explain why performance management is now under unprecedented scrutiny.



THE DISCONNECT

Despite mounting dissatisfaction, organisations continue to rely on performance reviews to make high-stakes decisions on pay, promotion, and progression. Yet confidence in these systems is thin. Deloitte's 2025 Global Human Capital Trends Report finds that only 32%